

Digital shield: Safeguarding children from the digital trap

The Indian government has **proposed** the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 to **fortify** children's online safety through **robust** data protection measures

The digital revolution has **profoundly** transformed how we live, learn, and connect. While this transformation offers **immense** opportunities for growth and development, it also **poses** significant risks, especially for **vulnerable** populations such as children. The digital world is **fraught with** challenges, from **exposure** to inappropriate content to **exploitation** through targeted advertising. Recognising the urgent need for robust protections, the Indian government has introduced the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025, under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023.

These rules, still in draft form, **have** the potential to safeguard children from falling into digital traps by establishing a **comprehensive** framework for responsible data handling. A **cornerstone** of the draft rules is the requirement for verifiable parental **consent** before processing children's data. This **mandate** ensures that entities cannot collect or use data about minors without **explicit** authorisation from their parents or legal **guardians**. For example, **creating** an account on a social media platform or an online gaming service **requires** parents to verify their identity and approve the data processing activities.

This provision is **vital** in reducing the risks posed by predatory targeting, identity theft, and unauthorised data collection. By putting parents in control, the rules prevent businesses from **exploiting** children's data for financial gain. This safeguard is particularly important in protecting children from **behavioural profiling**, which can have long-term implications on their **psychological** development and privacy.

Educational institutions play a critical role in a child's growth, but they, too, **rely** heavily on data collection. The draft rules explicitly **address** this by restricting data processing in schools and allied institutions to activities that are essential for educational purposes or the safety of students. **For instance**, tracking attendance, monitoring behaviour, and ensuring the security of transportation services are permissible, but excessive or irrelevant data collection is prohibited. These safeguards ensure that children's data is not misused or **repurposed** without clear justification.

The digital world can be a **double-edged sword**. While it offers educational resources and entertainment, it also **exposes** children to inappropriate or harmful content. The draft rules mandate that **data fiduciaries** implement measures to ensure that children cannot access content that negatively affects their **well-being**. This includes **filtering out** materials related to violence, explicit content, and other age-inappropriate material.

Such **provisions** are critical in protecting the mental and emotional health of children, who are particularly **susceptible to** the influence of harmful digital **stimuli**. **Moreover**, they **underscore** the importance of **collaboration** between regulators and technology companies to create a safer online

environment. Consent managers play a **pivotal** role in the new **framework**. As intermediaries, they enable data principals—in this case, parents or guardians—to give, manage, review, and withdraw consent for data processing activities. These managers must ensure that the process is **transparent** and user-friendly, **empowering** parents to **monitor** how their children's data is being utilised.

The draft rules also require consent managers to maintain detailed records of consent given, denied, or withdrawn, enhancing **accountability across the board**. While the draft rules represent a significant **leap** forward, their successful implementation **hinges** on **overcoming** several challenges. This **calls for** innovative solutions, such as integrating verified digital IDs like Aadhaar with consent management systems.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

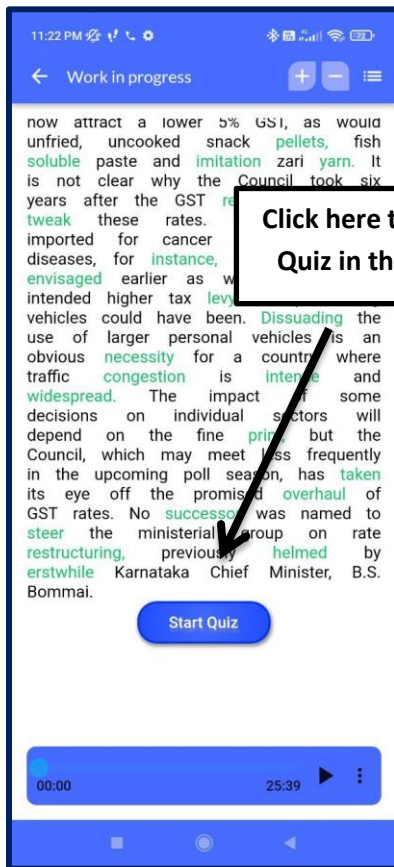
1. **Shield** (verb) – Protect, defend, safeguard, cover, guard बचाव करना
2. **Safeguard** (verb) – Secure, protect, shield, preserve, defend सुरक्षित रखना
3. **Propose** (verb) – Suggest, put forward, recommend, submit, offer प्रस्ताव रखना
4. **Fortify** (verb) – Strengthen, reinforce, secure, fortify, bolster मज़बूत करना
5. **Robust** (adjective) – Strong, solid, sturdy, resilient, vigorous मज़बूत
6. **Profoundly** (adverb) – Deeply, thoroughly, significantly, intensely, greatly बहुत गहराई से
7. **Immense** (adjective) – Huge, vast, massive, enormous, great विशाल
8. **Pose** (verb) – Present, create, cause, raise, bring about उत्पन्न करना
9. **Vulnerable** (adjective) – Susceptible, defenseless, exposed, fragile, weak असुरक्षित
10. **Fraught** (with) (adjective) – Filled with, loaded with, laden with, rife with भरा हुआ
11. **Exposure** (noun) – Revelation, showing, disclosure, unveiling, contact संपर्क या उजागर होना
12. **Exploitation** (noun) – Abuse, misuse, taking advantage, manipulation, oppression शोषण
13. **Comprehensive** (adjective) – Complete, thorough, all-inclusive, extensive, broad व्यापक
14. **Cornerstone** (noun) – Foundation, basis, bedrock, keystone, essential element आधारशिला
15. **Consent** (noun) – Permission, agreement, approval, authorization, assent सहमति
16. **Mandate** (noun) – Requirement, order, directive, command, injunction आदेश
17. **Explicit** (adjective) – Clear, direct, unambiguous, specific, clearly stated स्पष्ट
18. **Guardian** (noun) – Caretaker, custodian, protector, overseer संरक्षक
19. **Vital** (adjective) – Essential, crucial, critical, indispensable, key अत्यावश्यक
20. **Exploit** (verb) – Take advantage of, misuse, abuse, manipulate शोषण करना
21. **Behavioural profiling** (noun) – Tracking and analysis of behavior patterns to create targeted data or responses व्यवहारिक प्रोफाइलिंग
22. **Psychological** (adjective) – Mental, emotional, related to the mind मनोवैज्ञानिक
23. **Rely** (on) (verb) – Depend on, count on, trust in, bank on निर्भर होना

24. **Address** (verb) – Deal with, tackle, attend to, handle निपटना
25. **For instance** (phrase) – For example, to illustrate, such as, like उदाहरण के लिए
26. **Repurpose** (verb) – Redesign, reuse, adapt, convert for new use पुनः उपयोग करना
27. **Double-edge sword** (phrase) – Situation with both benefits and risks, mixed blessing, two-sided aspect दोधारी तलवार
28. **Expose** (verb) – Reveal, uncover, subject to, bring into contact उजागर करना
29. **Data fiduciary** (noun) – Entity entrusted with managing, using, or processing data responsibly डेटा अभिरक्षक
30. **Well-being** (noun) – Health, welfare, safety, comfort, happiness कुशलता
31. **Filter out** (phrasal verb) – Block, screen, remove unwanted elements, sift out छांटना
32. **Provision** (noun) – Clause, stipulation, requirement, arrangement प्रावधान
33. **Susceptible** (to) (adjective) – Vulnerable, prone, open to, liable to आसानी से प्रभावित
34. **Stimuli** (noun) – Triggers, inputs, prompts, signals उत्तेजनाएं
35. **Moreover** (adverb) – Furthermore, in addition, besides, also इसके अलावा
36. **Underscore** (verb) – Emphasize, highlight, stress, underline ज़ोर देना
37. **Collaboration** (noun) – Cooperation, partnership, teamwork, alliance सहयोग
38. **Pivotal** (adjective) – Crucial, central, essential, critical, key महत्वपूर्ण
39. **Framework** (noun) – Structure, system, scheme, plan ढांचा
40. **Transparent** (adjective) – Clear, open, straightforward, understandable पारदर्शी
41. **Empower** (verb) – Authorize, enable, permit, give power to सशक्त बनाना
42. **Monitor** (verb) – Watch, observe, supervise, keep track of निगरानी रखना
43. **Accountability** (noun) – Responsibility, answerability, liability, obligation जवाबदेही
44. **Across the board** (phrase) – Applying to everyone/everything, widespread, blanket, comprehensive एक समान रूप से
45. **Leap** (noun) – Big step, jump, advance, milestone बड़ी छलांग
46. **Hinge** (on) (verb) – Depend on, rest on, revolve around, be contingent on निर्भर होना
47. **Overcome** (verb) – Conquer, surmount, prevail over, triumph over पार पाना
48. **Call for** (phrasal verb) – Require, need, demand, request आवश्यकता होना

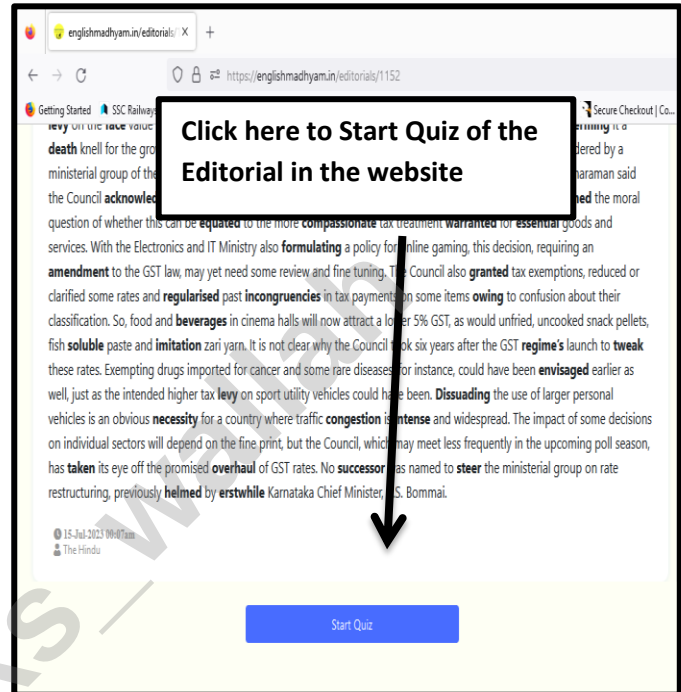
Summary of the Editorial

1. **Purpose of the Draft Rules:** The Indian government introduced the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 (under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023) to shield children from digital vulnerabilities.
2. **Scope of Protection:** These rules aim to address risks such as exposure to inappropriate content, targeted advertising, and potential exploitation of children's data.
3. **Parental Consent Mandate:** A key provision requires verifiable parental or guardian consent before processing any child's data, placing primary control in the hands of parents.
4. **Practical Implementation:** For example, setting up a social media or gaming account for a minor would necessitate explicit authorisation from the parent or guardian.
5. **Safeguarding Against Exploitation:** By ensuring parental oversight, the rules seek to thwart predatory targeting, identity theft, and commercial exploitation of minors' personal information.
6. **Limiting Behavioural Profiling:** Prohibiting businesses from collecting and using children's data without consent reduces the risk of long-term psychological and privacy harms caused by profiling.
7. **Educational Institutions Covered:** Schools and related institutions are explicitly guided to process only data that is essential for educational or safety purposes, preventing unnecessary or excessive data collection.
8. **Clear Justification for Data Use:** Activities like attendance tracking or monitoring transportation services are allowed, but repurposing or misusing student data is prohibited.
9. **Age-Appropriate Content Restrictions:** The rules obligate data fiduciaries to block children's access to harmful or adult content, reinforcing a safer digital environment.
10. **Mental Health Emphasis:** These safeguards acknowledge the mental and emotional impact of harmful digital stimuli on children, necessitating stringent content control.
11. **Industry Collaboration:** The rules encourage regulators and technology companies to work together to develop and maintain safe, child-friendly online platforms.
12. **Role of Consent Managers:** Designated intermediaries help parents grant, review, manage, or withdraw consent for any data processing related to their children.
13. **Accountability Through Record-Keeping:** Consent managers must maintain detailed records of parental permissions, boosting transparency and responsibility.
14. **Implementation Hurdles:** Effective enforcement of these rules depends on resolving practical challenges, including robust digital identity verification mechanisms.
15. **Potential Integrations:** Linking verified digital IDs (like Aadhaar) with consent management systems is proposed to streamline verification and ensure secure, reliable implementation of the new regulations.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



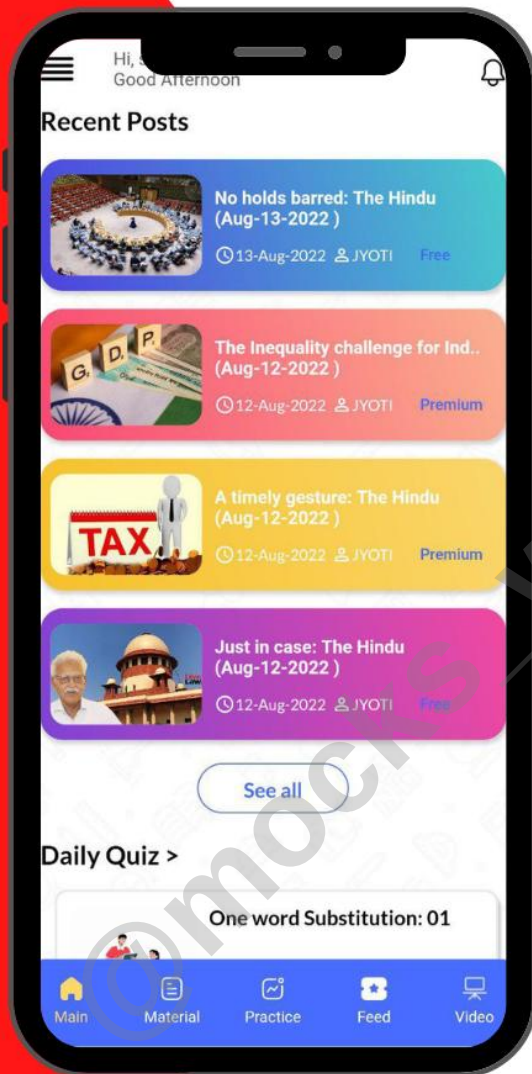
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